

Acts for Abolition Bible Study with Jeremy Williams

Recording Links, Reflection Prompts and Further Reading

<https://clbsj.org/events/2026/06/23/acts-for-abolition/>



SESSION 1: ACTS 2:14-28

In the first session, Dr. Williams gives an overview of what abolition means both generally and in our context, and presents some tools for reading the passages in Acts that refer to the criminalization of Jesus and his disciples. We then focus in on how Acts 2:14-47 establishes the “Holy Spirit of Abolition” as the foundation of the church.

Session 1 Recording Link:

<https://us02web.zoom.us/rec/share/ig3ZjceSnvYu3bZ--XhyYTCKDu-b2cPEXpkFuM8WiNEXGp1eRYo8qMEDCJdcfJtP.CgLQTd5e7pg2pQa?startTime=1785966634000>

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Session 1 Reflection Prompts:

1. What do you think of the assertion that New Testament references to Hell and Hades were referring to actual underground prisons? (Here is the instagram video that we discussed but did not watch: <https://www.instagram.com/reels/Da20qfiEhEA/>)
2. How does Dr. Williams’ analysis of the underlying causes of incarceration and criminalization (both now and in biblical times) change how you read Acts 2:36-38?
3. Who do you think is similar to "Liberti" in our current context? (Here is some more information on the statue Dr. Williams named “Liberti”: <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/250657>) Who should we be reading with and for, today?

SESSION 2: ACTS 6:1-15

In the second session, we take a deeper dive into the history of abolitionist thinking and how it’s critique of prisons, policing and private property connect to the biblical context as well as to our times. We then engage with Acts 6:1-15 as an example of a time when the nature of the Holy Spirit of Abolition’s call on the community was being deliberated.

Session 2 Recording Link:

https://us02web.zoom.us/rec/share/7jN7zJNrdDJhMrV214khhb_5B8aKhZqmpqFltw0NCvEqnYMLnxFMzk7Emg569Wz8.bC23er3mpE47qHWa?startTime=1786570991000

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Session 2 Reflection Prompts:

1. How can we read the Bible as “friends of Liberti?” What gets in the way of us reading in this way?
2. What did you think of Dr. Williams’ translation of Luke 4:18-19, and how does it inform your answer to these questions: What was the nature of the Spirit that filled Stephen in Acts 6:5. What was Jesus anointed (made Christ)

to do? You can see Dr. Williams' translation of Luke 4:18-19 in the recording at 1:01:20, and/or in this article: <https://www.workingpreacher.org/commentaries/revised-common-lectionary/third-sunday-of-easter/commentary-on-acts-214a-36-41-3>

3. How do you see attempts to dismantle and re-imagine the “3-Ps” (prisons, police and private property) going on in the passages in Acts we’ve worked with? What similar efforts are you aware of and/or involved in today?

SESSION 3: ACTS 5:17-42

In the third session, Dr. Williams recaps the cultural and political variables involved in reading Acts “as Friends of Liberty.” He introduces Vincent Wimbush’s understanding of how scripture operates within a sphere of meaning-making, and challenged us to ask not “what does the scripture mean,” but rather asking “HOW does the scripture mean?” He then presents his own translation of Acts 5:17-42, which details the relationship between the Apostles’ teachings on abolition with the repeated efforts to imprison them.

Session 3 Recording Link:

<https://us02web.zoom.us/rec/share/eF3FK7wKCZDHqeAjrGc5RM5I6hwUu5QTuN1HuQyXvN2rOc7qS-Zhe8SaKW1uDKxv.KET4CodTLuCEVrkM?startTime=1787176852000>

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Session 3 Reflection Prompts:

1. What parts of Dr. Williams’ translation of Acts 5:17-34, 38-39 spoke to you most strongly, and why? For those of you who are engaged in abolitionist organizing, which verses in this translation feels most connected to / resonant with your work?
2. What do you think of the assertion that Liberty’s people were the abolitionists of biblical times, and may be thought of as precursors to our current movements?
3. Dr. Williams asked us, “with whom are you reading the Bible?” How does thinking about this question change the way you identify with the different characters and groups in Acts 5:17-42? What “clubs,” parties” or “groups” (verse 5:17 - hairesis) are they a part of — and what groups would you be a part of, if you were there? Do we get to choose which groups we are in – what does the scripture imply, and what do you think?

SESSION 4: ACTS 12:1-19

In the final session, Dr. Williams works with Acts 12:1-19, in which we meet an enslaved girl named Rhoda who seems to be owned by the Jesus-following community. Dr. Williams’ translation opens the door for reflection on the importance of facing contradictions within the Bible, within our churches, and within ourselves. He also provided us with with a tool, “CRASH Course on Interpreter’s Audience,” to support us in thinking in a disciplined way about who we are reading the Bible with and for.

Session 4 Recording Link:

https://us02web.zoom.us/rec/share/tJvHfrDHjRinq3jxR0_sVedhf8XfwirsmIW1CbuRq0f8IrYC1VY35CI-YkzGwIFH.aTZ5xROV0kFgv9N0?startTime=1787781426000

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Session 4 Reflection Prompts:

1. Dr. Williams discussed how his method of “Reading with Liberti” has been shaped by Saidiya Hartman’s method, “critical fabulation.” Does this concept help you connect more deeply with Liberti and his people?
2. How do you react to Dr. Williams’ translation of 12:17b, that “the Lord/Adonai/Enslaver had brought [Peter] out of custody”?
3. Of the contradictions that Dr. Williams discussed in Acts 12:1-19, which ones struck you the most and why? Do you see similar contradictions within our nations, our churches, our movements, ourselves?
4. In what ways has this mini-course been a “Crossroads” experience for you?

SUGGESTED READINGS:

Aymer, Margaret. “Outrageous, Audacious, Courageous, Willful: Reading the Enslaved Girl of Acts 12.”

https://drive.google.com/file/d/1gZ0oEgUw8UlgAOLDPWWhP88V_vOXptX35/view?usp=sharing

Davis, Angela Y et al. *Abolition. Feminism. Now.* Haymarket, 2022

Dubler, Joshua and Lloyd, Vincent. *Break Every Yoke: Religion, Justice, and the Abolition of Prisons.* Oxford, 2019. Especially “Chapter 5: Spirit of Abolition”

Gilmore, Ruth Wilson. *Abolition Geography: Essays Toward Liberation.* Verso, 2023

Gilmore, Ruth Wilson and Murakawa, Naomi. *Change Everything: Racial Capitalism and the Case for Abolition.* Haymarket, 2024

Griffith, Lee. *The Fall of the Prison: Biblical Perspectives on Prison Abolition.* Eerdmans, 1993. Especially “Chapter V: Prisons and Discipleship”

Kaba, Mariame. *We Do This ‘Til We Free Us: Abolitionist Organizing and Transforming Justice.* Haymarket, 2021

Kelley, Robin D.G. “Black Study, Black Struggle,” 2018. <https://scispace.com/papers/black-study-black-struggle-54tmkgs3av>

Krinks, Andrew. *White Property, Black Trespass: Racial Capitalism and the Religious Function of Mass Criminalization.* NYU Press, 2024. Especially “Introduction: The Religion of Mass Criminalization”

Larsen, Matthew D.C. and Letteney, Mark. *Ancient Mediterranean Incarceration.* University of California Press, 2025

Purnell, Derecka. *Becoming Abolitionists: Police, Protests, and the Pursuit of Freedom.* Astra House, 2021. Especially “Chapter 4: Love and Abolition” and “Chapter 6: Sex, Love and Violence.”

Smith, Mitzi J. *Chloe and Her People: A Womanist Critical Dialogue with First Corinthians.* Cascade 2023. Especially “Chapter 2: Chloe, a Freedwoman in First-Century Corinth, and Frances Watkins Harper's Aunt Chloe”

Wimbush, Vincent L. *White Men’s Magic: Scripturalization as Slavery.* Oxford, 2014

Zeichmann, Christopher B. *Radical Antiquity: Free Love, Zoroastrians, Farming Pirates and Ancient Uprisings.* Pluto, 2025